

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

## CORE FORMULA

Pause after key exchange -> Mirror what you understood -> Check accuracy

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

After any exchange where misalignment is possible, say: 'What I understood from that is X — is that right?' Then listen.

## BEST FOR

- Complex or high-stakes conversations where misunderstanding is costly
- Meetings where decisions are made verbally
- Situations where instructions or expectations are given
- Any conversation where both parties might leave with different interpretations

## PHRASE BANK

### Summary Checks · Confirming understanding

- "What I am taking away from this is..."
- "Let me check I have understood: you are saying..."
- "So the upshot is X — is that right?"
- "My read of this is... does that match yours?"
- "Just to confirm: we are agreed on X?"
- "I want to make sure we are aligned — my understanding is..."
- "Before we move on — I understood that to mean..."
- "Checking: the decision we just made is..."

### Check Invitations · Inviting correction

- "Tell me if I have that wrong."
- "Correct me if I have missed anything."
- "Is there something in that I have missed?"
- "Where am I off?"
- "Is my read accurate?"

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Walking out of a meeting without confirming what was decided  
Better: Just to recap before we go...  
**Best: Specific summary of each decision with owner and timeline, confirmed by the group.**
2. Weak: Assuming you understood without checking  
Better: I think I understood — let me know if not.  
**Best: 'My understanding is X — is that right?' Then actually listen for the correction.**
3. Weak: Summarising in a way that re-argues your point  
Better: Let me recap what was said.  
**Best: Neutral summary that reflects what was actually said, not your preferred version.**

## DECISION TREE

**If A decision was made verbally and you want to confirm it**

Summarise the decision back in one sentence.

*"So we are going with X, and the deadline is Y — is that correct?"*

**If You are unsure what was meant**

Summarise your interpretation and ask if it is right.

*"I want to check I understood — my read was X. Did I get that right?"*

**If Someone else is unsure what was meant**

Offer to summarise for them.

*"Let me say back what I understood and see if that helps."*

**If You are at the end of a long meeting**

Summarise the key decisions and owners before ending.

*"Before we close — the three things we agreed on are: ..."*

## SCENARIOS

**End of a meeting where decisions were made**

Name each decision, who owns it, and by when. — *"Before we close — we decided X, Y owns it, and the deadline is Z."*

**After receiving complex instructions**

Summarise back before starting the work. — *"Let me check I have that right: you need X done by Y in Z format."*

**After a tense conversation where alignment is uncertain**

Summarise what was agreed without editorialising. — *"My understanding of where we landed is... Is that yours too?"*

**After a long discussion where the thread was lost**

Name what you think the conclusion was. — *"I want to make sure we did not lose the thread — I think the decision was X."*

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- In casual conversations where paraphrasing would feel clinical or overly formal.
- When you genuinely understood and a summary check would waste the other person's time.
- In some cultures and relationships where it signals distrust or condescension.

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

**Day 1 — End-of-meeting recap**

At the end of one meeting, summarise the decisions made and confirm with the room.

**Day 2 — After instructions**

After receiving any instructions or requests today, summarise them back before you start.

**Day 3 — Check one assumption**

Identify one assumption you have made in a conversation and check it explicitly.

**Day 4 — Neutral summary**

Practice summarising what was said without adding your interpretation or opinion.

**Day 5 — The short check**

Use a one-sentence summary check in three conversations today.

**Day 6 — Written summary**

After a key meeting, send a short email summary of what was decided.

**Day 7 — Calibration**

Did your checks catch any misalignments? Were any summaries corrected? Did any feel like slowing things down?

## AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I pause at the right moment to check understanding?
- Did I summarise accurately — without adding my preferred interpretation?
- Did I explicitly invite correction?
- Did I listen to the response rather than just confirming my summary?

- Did I use this at the end of key meetings and conversations?
- Did I act on any corrections that came from the check?
- Did I avoid over-using it to the point of slowing things down?